# St. Mary's Academy: Built On Faith, Carried By Legacy

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*This interview was conducted with Pamela Rogers, President/Head of School; Valencia Duncan(SMA Alumna,'84), Dean of Students; Tamiko Massey-Haynes (SMA Alumna, '89), Director of Strategic Initiatives and Admissions; Darlene Hutchinson, Primary/Elementary School Coordinator (SMA Alumna, '77), and Sandra Regis, Administrative Assistant.*

*For more than a century, 158 years to be exact, St. Mary's Academy (SMA) has been a staple institution serving young ladies across the city. SMA is an all-girl Catholic Pre K-12 school. Founded by the Sisters of the Holy Family, the second-oldest order of African American nuns in the country, SMA is also one of the oldest Black high schools in the country.*

*The institution prides itself on educating the "whole person"-spiritually, mentally, socially, physically, and culturally. The school boasts 100% graduation and college acceptance rates. And you are sure to find an SMA alumna, as they have not only remained in New Orleans but have also expanded globally. SMA graduates have contributed to a variety of industries, including business, healthcare, politics, culinary, and the arts. The school is also infamously recognized for students who provided additional solutions to the centuries-old Pythagorean Theorem.*

*After Hurricane Katrina, the administration felt even more compelled to return because there was an absolute need for an institution like SMA in the community. Even without knowing what building would house the students after significant damage to the campus, the mission was clear, and a return was bound to happen in some way.*

**Q: How has BCM's funding and support opened doors that might not have otherwise been possible for St. Mary's Academy?**

**Rogers:** The BCM grant was really a blessing to us. When we applied for the grant, we were hoping that we would win, of course. One of the things that we needed at that time and had been very prayerful about was [additional] lighting for the campus. We are, of course, located in New Orleans East, and lighting is really not as prevalent as it should be [in this area]. And, we knew it would be costly. We wanted our students, parents, and visitors to be safe and comfortable. We also used some of the funds to enhance safety features on our campus so that our young people would feel protected.

**Q: Twenty years after Hurricane Katrina, what does St. Mary's Academy's existence say about New Orleans' resilience and the community's ability to rebuild on its own terms?**

**Duncan:** Just like any other institution after Hurricane Katrina, we were very limited with resources, but we wanted to go out there and get every single resource that we could to benefit our students here at St. Mary's Academy, and we have grown tremendously with those resources. We are still looking for resources.

**Massey-Haynes:** I don't think it was about rebuilding the structure of the school, but much more about having a place for legacies to return. And continue the legacy. St. Mary's is a pillar of the community, and it is part of the fabric of this city, so we had to see it come back.

**Q: When you think about the next 20 years, what role do you see St. Mary's Academy playing in the continued recovery and reimaging of New Orleans?**

**Rogers:** We believe that we will be at the forefront of education in New Orleans. We are looking at innovative ways to educate our young people. We have built another building, which is on the same site as the Hurricane Katrina destruction, and we look forward to continuing to expand the school in the next 20 years. Our goal is to move into other areas to share the vision of the Sisters of the Holy Family and our foundress, the Venerable Henriette Delille. We believe that every young person deserves the right to a quality education because that is what we offer here, and that is what we would like more students to receive.

**Hutchinson:** I think St. Mary's Academy has been that spark of hope. The hope that we could rebuild, or we could go forward and be creative. It was during the Katrina devastation that something was ignited in all of that despair. St. Mary's Academy is a pioneering institution. It was going to be rebuilt, and we didn't know how, but we said a lot of prayers. And in some way, we found a way to rebuild this school, while keeping our traditions going. And that light of hope, that spark, has shown to others in the community that this school is a pivotal institution. There is so much vibrant life, relationships, and family building that is here. It is priceless to have this experience, being a Maryite.

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